

Kogan Page Book Proposal

By Stella Bayles

1. Biography
 2. Proposed title and subtitle
 3. One-sentence summary/elevator pitch
 4. Detailed vision/philosophy of the book
 5. Table of contents with chapter summaries
 6. Competitive analysis
 7. Target audience and reader challenges
 8. Estimated word count and delivery timeline
 9. Endorsements
 10. Marketing
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1. Biography

Stella Bayles is a communications strategist, PR measurement specialist, speaker, author, and industry educator best known for helping modernise how the public relations industry measures impact and demonstrates value. She is currently Head of Industry Relations at CoverageBook, where she works at the intersection of modern PR practice, stakeholder reporting, and AI-ready measurement.

With more than 20 years of experience spanning agency, consultancy, in-house, and PR technology roles, Stella has built a reputation as one of the industry's leading advocates for smarter, more accessible PR measurement. Before joining CoverageBook, she spent over 14 years agency-side, initially in traditional public relations before becoming one of the early practitioners in Europe to combine SEO strategy with PR campaigns and communications measurement. Her work helped major brands better connect communications activity with business outcomes, contributing to significant client growth, multiple industry award wins, and substantial agency revenue growth.

At CoverageBook, Stella works closely with PR teams globally and has firsthand visibility into how communications professionals are adapting reporting, measurement, and AI workflows in real time. Her work focuses on helping PR teams move away from vanity metrics and retrospective reporting towards structured, insight-led measurement systems that support stronger strategic decision-making and clearer evidence of organisational impact.

She regularly speaks internationally on topics including PR analytics, communications measurement, data literacy, AI in PR, reporting strategy, and the integration of PR with wider marketing disciplines. Stella has spoken at major industry events including PRSA ICON, AMEC conferences, PRCA events, PRWeek forums, and international communications conferences across the UK, Europe, and North America.

Stella is also the host of the long-running PR Resolution Podcast, where she interviews leaders across PR, communications, SEO, analytics, and marketing technology. Through podcasting, webinars, conference speaking, industry training, and university guest lecturing, she has educated thousands of communications professionals internationally.

She is the author of PR's Digital Resolution (2016), an early guide exploring digital PR, SEO integration, and communications measurement. She has also contributed to industry initiatives and educational programmes with organisations including AMEC and the PRCA, particularly around data literacy, communications evaluation, and the future of PR measurement.

Known for translating complex measurement concepts into practical, accessible guidance, Stella advocates for a more evidence-led PR industry where communications professionals feel confident using structured insight to improve strategy, demonstrate value, and adapt to the future of AI-assisted communications.

2. Proposed title & sub-title

Proof of Influence

How ~~Modern~~ PR Teams Measure What Matters

3. One-sentence summary

Proof of Influence helps modern PR teams measure what matters by providing a simple, practical framework for connecting communications activity to meaningful outcomes without needing specialist analytics expertise.

4. Detailed Book Vision

PR measurement was never supposed to become this intimidating.

Somewhere along the way, the communications industry turned measurement into something that felt overly technical, specialist, and disconnected from the reality of modern PR work. At exactly the same time, PR teams started being asked tougher strategic questions than ever before.

Today, communications professionals are expected to prove value, demonstrate organisational impact, contribute to commercial decision making, and explain what is influencing outcomes in real time. But much of the industry is still relying on measurement systems built for a far simpler and traditional media landscape.

PR is no longer just newspaper coverage, broadcast interviews, and end-of-campaign reports.

Influence now happens across creators, communities, podcasts, newsletters, Reddit threads, LinkedIn conversations, YouTube videos, stakeholder networks, and increasingly, AI-generated search experiences. Audiences discover information differently, trust information differently, and engage with brands differently than they did even a few years ago.

Yet despite this shift, much of PR measurement still focuses on counting outputs rather than understanding influence.

Reporting often remains retrospective. Dashboards become overloaded with disconnected metrics. And too many PR professionals still feel like measurement belongs to analysts or “numbers people” instead of the people closest to the communications work itself.

That gap matters because PR has never had more strategic opportunity than it does right now.

Communications teams increasingly influence:

- reputation
- stakeholder trust
- executive visibility
- crisis response
- cultural relevance
- market positioning
- search visibility
- AI visibility
- organisational credibility

But with that influence comes pressure.

Pressure to justify budgets.

Pressure to connect communications activity to business outcomes.

Pressure to explain what is working.

And pressure to adapt faster when it is not.

Too often, the industry responds to that pressure with even more complexity: bigger dashboards, more jargon, disconnected KPIs, and reporting systems that feel impossible for normal PR teams to consistently maintain.

Proof of Influence argues the answer is actually the opposite.

Simpler systems.

Better structure.

More consistency.

More confidence.

And measurement that becomes part of everyday strategic thinking rather than something saved for the end of a campaign.

At the centre of the book is a practical framework:

The Influence Drivers Framework

Built around one core principle:

Consistent drivers. Flexible outcomes.

The framework introduces a simpler way for PR teams to classify communications activity using four fixed drivers:

- Activity
- Published Format
- Sentiment
- Brand Prominence

These drivers create a consistent layer of structured communications data that allows PR teams to:

- benchmark performance over time
- compare campaigns consistently
- identify patterns
- surface strategic insights
- strengthen reporting systems
- prepare communications data for AI analysis

Outcomes then remain flexible depending on what success actually looks like for each campaign.

One campaign may focus on reputation.

Another on stakeholder trust.

Another on search visibility, AI visibility, lead generation, or commercial impact.

The book argues that one of the biggest mistakes the PR industry has historically made is trying to force every campaign into identical KPIs, while simultaneously failing to create consistent underlying communications data.

Modern PR measurement should not be about forcing communications into false certainty.

Instead, it should function as:

“A system of evidence for attempts at influence.”

That distinction is important because PR does not operate in isolation and influence is rarely linear. Communications activity contributes to wider organisational outcomes alongside marketing, sales, product, customer experience, leadership, and market conditions.

The goal is not to claim PR caused every business result.

The goal is to build credible, structured systems that help organisations better understand:

- what is gaining traction
- what is influencing outcomes
- what patterns are emerging
- and where strategy should evolve next

The rise of AI makes this moment even more important.

For the first time, smaller PR teams now have access to analytical capabilities that previously only existed inside large organisations with dedicated analyst departments. AI can help communications teams identify patterns, surface anomalies, summarise reporting, accelerate insight generation, and support faster strategic decision making.

But AI is only as useful as the information it is given.

Most PR teams still do not have their communications data organised in a way AI can reliably interpret or analyse. Recent research conducted by CoverageBook across UK and US PR professionals found that:

- 68% agree PR budget decisions made without structured coverage analysis are essentially guesswork
- 85% do not use a formal method to assess coverage quality
- 50% are not confident their communications data is reliable for AI analysis

Proof of Influence positions structured PR measurement as the bridge between traditional communications practice and the future of AI-assisted strategy.

A major differentiator of the book is accessibility.

Many PR measurement books still feel like they were written primarily for analysts, specialists, or academic audiences. This book is intentionally written for real PR professionals working in the real world: agency teams, in-house communications professionals, consultants, strategists, founders, educators, and practitioners moving into more strategic leadership roles.

Especially those who currently feel intimidated by data, dashboards, analytics, or AI.

Part of the philosophy behind the book comes from my own journey. I used to actively avoid maths lessons at school. Now I spend my career helping PR teams build measurement systems, structure communications data, and understand strategic analysis.

That experience taught me something important:

the biggest barrier to measurement is often confidence and identity, not intelligence.

PR professionals are often the best people to evaluate their own work because they understand:

- the messaging
- the stakeholders
- the objectives
- the audience
- the relationships
- and the nuance behind influence

better than anyone else.

This book reframes PR measurement from something separate from communications into something embedded within strategic communications practice itself.

Throughout the book, practical workflows, sector-specific case studies, reporting systems, AI-ready approaches, and real-world communications examples bridge the gap between theory and implementation.

Ultimately, Proof of Influence is not just a book about PR measurement.

It is a book about helping PR professionals become:

- more strategic
- more evidence-led
- more commercially influential
- more confident
- more adaptable
- and more prepared for the future of communications

Because measurement should no longer feel like a reporting task that happens after the work is finished.

It should become an everyday strategic system for understanding, improving, and evidencing influence in real time.

5. Table of Contents

TITLE:

Proof of Influence

How Modern PR Teams Measure What Matters

Introduction

PR Changed Faster Than Measurement Did

PR has changed dramatically in recent years, from the formats audiences consume to the platforms shaping trust and influence. Yet PR measurement has largely remained stuck in retrospective reporting models built for a very different media landscape.

This introduction explores why modern PR professionals can no longer afford to outsource measurement, wait until campaigns end to understand performance, or rely on outdated reporting methods. It introduces the book's core argument: that PR professionals must become

evidence led strategists, and that structured data and AI analysis can now make this more accessible than ever before.

PART 1 — THE PROBLEM

Chapter 1 — Why PR Measurement Failed

This chapter examines how PR measurement became disconnected from modern strategic communications. It explores how reporting evolved into a process of proving activity rather than improving performance, and how complex frameworks, vanity metrics, and specialist silos created an industry wide fear of measurement.

The chapter also explores how other areas of marketing have become increasingly evidence led, data informed, and optimisation focused over the past two decades, while PR often remained reliant on retrospective reporting and output focused KPIs. It examines how this weakened PR's strategic influence within organisations and contributed to budget shifts towards channels able to demonstrate clearer commercial impact.

Drawing on recent UK and US senior PR industry research carried out by CoverageBook, the chapter highlights the ongoing confidence gap around measurement, data literacy, reporting, and proving value across communications teams.

The chapter argues that PR lost influence not because the work lacked creativity or value, but because it struggled to evidence impact in ways businesses could understand and trust.

Chapter 2 — Why You Are the Best Person for the Job

This chapter challenges the belief that measurement belongs only to “numbers people” or specialist analysts. Through Stella's personal journey from avoiding maths at school to becoming a recognised voice in PR measurement, the chapter explores why the real barrier to measurement is often confidence and identity rather than ability.

It introduces the book's central thesis: that measurement must be democratised across PR teams, and that the people closest to the work are best placed to understand, analyse, and improve it.

PART 2 — THE NEW MODEL

Chapter 3 — What Does Success Actually Look Like?

This chapter highlights one of the biggest problems in PR measurement: most teams start campaigns without properly agreeing what success actually means.

As PR becomes more strategically important inside organisations, stakeholder interest also continues to grow. Sales teams, product teams, CEOs, investors, internal communications teams,

and marketing departments may all want completely different things from the same PR activity. This means there is no single universal PR outcome.

The chapter explores why outcomes should be flexible depending on:

- objectives
- audiences
- stakeholders
- business context

At the same time, it argues that while:

- the creative changes
- the campaign changes
- the platforms change
- the activity changes

...the way PR teams classify and track communications activity must remain consistent.

The chapter introduces the importance of consistently tracking:

- activity
- published format
- sentiment
- brand prominence
- audience response

so that PR teams can build a reliable and comparable body of communications data over time.

It argues that modern PR measurement is not about forcing every campaign into identical KPIs. It is about layering flexible outcomes onto consistent structured data to create better insight, stronger strategy, and more meaningful AI analysis.

Ultimately, the chapter suggests a new position for modern PR measurement as:

“A system of evidence for attempts at influence.”

Chapter 4 — Building Your PR Intelligence System

This chapter introduces the book’s core framework:

The Influence Drivers Framework

Consistent drivers. Flexible outcomes.

It explores why modern PR teams need a consistent shared classification system in order to properly understand performance, compare campaigns over time, and prepare communications data for AI analysis. From team through to industry level this will explain how comparison allows us to level up as an industry.

The chapter tackles common industry objections such as:

- “Every campaign is different”
- “What about media tiers?”
- “What about all the other measurement metrics?”

and explains why PR teams should classify coverage based on what drives performance, not the performance itself.

It introduces the concept of fixed drivers and flexible outcomes, explaining why drivers should remain consistent over time while outcomes should adapt depending on campaign objectives and stakeholder needs.

The chapter also explores why media tiers and intended audiences are planning tools rather than foundational drivers, and introduces the importance of structured communications data as the foundation for:

- benchmarking
- comparison
- strategic learning
- AI analysis

Chapter 5 — Drivers

The Fixed Layer of Modern PR Measurement

This chapter explores the fixed drivers that sit at the centre of the book’s framework and explains how they create consistency, comparability, and strategic insight over time.

The chapter breaks down the four core drivers in detail:

- Activity
- Published Format
- Sentiment
- Brand Prominence

For each driver, the chapter explores:

- what it means
- why it matters

- how it influences performance
- how to classify it consistently
- how it applies across different sectors and campaign types

The chapter will include practical examples and case studies from consumer PR, B2B, corporate, public affairs & crisis communications on all modern platforms and a variety of coverage formats.

It also explores the tools, workflows, and reporting systems PR teams can use to operationalise driver tracking consistently across campaigns, teams, and markets.

The chapter argues that keeping drivers fixed is what allows PR teams to build reliable data over time, identify patterns, compare performance, and generate more meaningful AI powered analysis.

Chapter 6 — Outcomes

Measuring What Success Looks Like

This chapter looks at outcomes as the flexible layer of modern PR measurement and explains how they should adapt depending on campaign goals, stakeholders and business context.

The chapter examines a wide range of potential PR outcomes including:

- audience reach
- reputation factors
- share of voice/search
- sales impact
- lead generation
- website traffic
- stakeholder confidence
- LLM visibility

The chapter includes practical examples and case studies from multiple PR sectors showing how different campaigns require different outcome metrics and measurement approaches.

It also explores the tools, reporting methods and data sources used to measure and evidence outcomes effectively.

The chapter reinforces the core 'Influence Drivers Framework':

- fixed drivers create consistency
- flexible outcomes create relevance

Together creating a more strategic, adaptable, and useful model for modern PR measurement.

Chapter 7 — Joining the Dots

From Tracking to Insight & Strategy

This chapter explains what happens after PR teams begin consistently tracking drivers and outcomes: how to surface meaningful insights and use them to improve strategy in real time.

The chapter argues that modern PR measurement should not end with reporting. The real value comes from identifying patterns, spotting opportunities, adapting activity, and helping organisations make better decisions faster.

It explores the importance of:

- regularly reviewing communications data
- identifying trends
- understanding what is driving outcomes
- turning insight into strategic action

The chapter also focuses heavily on stakeholder communication and explains why PR teams should stop waiting until the end of campaigns to report results. Instead, it explores the importance of continuously keeping stakeholders informed through regular updates that build trust, confidence, and influence at senior levels.

The chapter examines how different stakeholders require different insights depending on their priorities, and how PR professionals can connect activity, drivers, and outcomes back to the objectives different departments care about most.

It includes practical examples, expert commentary, and strategic perspectives from leading PR people on how to turn measurement into smarter communications strategy.

Chapter 8 — Telling the Story: Bringing Proof of Influence to Life

This chapter highlights the importance of data storytelling and explains why insight alone is not enough if PR teams cannot communicate it clearly, confidently, and strategically.

The chapter brings the concept of *Proof of Influence* to life by exploring the relationship between:

- stakeholder objectives
- PR drivers
- communications outcomes
- strategic business impact

It examines how PR professionals can tell stronger stories using structured data, trends, comparisons, and visualisation techniques that help stakeholders understand not just what happened, but why it mattered.

It will help build confidence in PR practitioners language and demonstrate how to bring data-led evidence into everyday communication with teams and stakeholders.

The chapter includes **sector specific case studies and examples**. It also explores the tools and techniques used to visualise communications data, simplify complex reporting, and create compelling stakeholder narratives that strengthens confidence.

PART 3 — THE AI ERA

Chapter 9 — AI As Your Data Team

This chapter explores how AI is transforming PR analysis and reporting. It explains why structured communications data is essential for effective AI analysis, and how AI agents can help PR teams identify patterns, generate strategic insights, help automate reporting, and optimise campaigns in real time.

The chapter also demonstrates how smaller PR teams can now perform sophisticated analysis previously only available to large agencies with dedicated analyst departments.

Chapter 10 — The Future PR Strategist

The final chapter looks at what the future of PR looks like in an AI supported, evidence led communications environment. It argues that modern PR professionals will become more strategic, adaptive, and commercially influential by combining human judgement with structured insight and AI assisted analysis.

The chapter concludes by reinforcing the book's core message: measurement should no longer feel intimidating, inaccessible, or separate from PR practice. Instead, it should become an everyday strategic skill that gives PR professionals more confidence, more agility, and more influence.

6. Competitive analysis

There are already several respected PR measurement books in the market, including titles by Tom Watson, Paul Noble, David Michaelson, Don Stacks, and Gini Dietrich. However, many of the core books still shaping industry thinking today were published before some of the biggest shifts in modern communications took place.

Since then, PR has changed dramatically.

Audiences increasingly consume information through creators, social platforms, podcasts, newsletters, and AI generated search environments rather than traditional publisher led journeys. PR activity now spans multiple formats and platforms, yet much of the industry still relies on measurement approaches built for a more traditional media environment.

At the same time, communications professionals are increasingly expected to provide strategic insight, evidence of organisational impact, and commercially relevant recommendations, while also navigating growing pressure around AI adoption and data readiness.

This creates a clear gap in the current publishing market.

While newer PR books tend to focus on broader communications strategy, branding, digital marketing, or AI theory, there are very few practical books focused specifically on helping everyday PR professionals build simple, modern measurement systems for the AI era.

That is where *Proof of Influence* is different.

Rather than approaching measurement from an academic or analyst perspective, the book is written from my (Stella Bayles') own experience moving from creative PR practitioner to one of the industry's leading voices on modern PR measurement and communications insight.

Its core philosophy is that measurement should no longer be a retrospective reporting task owned by specialists, but an everyday strategic skill that helps PR professionals understand what is working, improve communications activity faster, strengthen stakeholder confidence, and prove influence more credibly in the modern communications environment.

Unlike traditional PR measurement books written primarily for evaluation specialists, or academic audiences, *Proof of Influence* is written for the wider PR industry (the real PR professional!). It combines practical implementation, accessible language, AI-era relevance, and structured strategic thinking for modern communications teams working across fragmented media environments.

The book positions measurement not as a specialist reporting function, but as an everyday capability that helps PR professionals make better decisions, communicate value more clearly, and adapt faster in a changing communications landscape.

7. Target Audience for the Book, their Needs and Challenges

Proof of Influence is written for PR and communications professionals from Account Manager level upwards who are under increasing pressure to prove value, demonstrate impact, and make better strategic decisions using communications data.

The book is aimed at both agency and in house professionals including:

- Account Managers
- PR Managers
- Communications Managers
- Account Directors
- Client Partners
- Heads of PR
- Communications Directors
- Corporate Affairs professionals
- Independent consultants

It is particularly relevant for professionals moving into more strategic, stakeholder facing roles where they are expected to:

- justify budgets
- prove PR impact
- report to leadership teams
- connect communications activity to organisational goals
- navigate AI and data led decision making

Recent industry research carried out by Stella on behalf of CoverageBook identified recurring frustrations across PR teams including:

- proving PR's value
- inconsistent reporting systems
- reliance on spreadsheets
- lack of real time insight
- pressure to understand AI

The book is designed for professionals who want to become more strategic and evidence led without needing to become analysts or data scientists. It positions measurement as a practical communications skill that should sit within everyday PR work.

8. Case studies, word count & draft timeline

Case Study Plan

The book will include:

- 12–15 practical examples and case studies
- Case studies will include a mixture of agency, in-house, B2B, consumer, corporate, influencer, and crisis communications examples, alongside expert commentary and practitioner interviews.
- There will be heavier case study usage in Chapters 5 and 6
- expert quotes/interviews mainly in Chapters 7 and 8

75,000 Word Plan & Suggested 6 Month Delivery Schedule

Chapter	Approx Words	Delivery Month
Introduction	3,000	Month 1
Chapter 1 — Why PR Measurement Failed	6,000	Month 1
Chapter 2 — Why You Are the Best Person for the Job	6,000	Month 1
Chapter 3 — What Does Success Actually Look Like?	6,000	Month 2
Chapter 4 — Building Your PR Intelligence System	5,000	Month 2

Chapter 5 — Drivers	11,000	Month 3
Chapter 6 — Outcomes	11,000	Month 4
Chapter 7 — Joining the Dots	5,000	Month 5
Chapter 8 — Telling the Story	5,000	Month 5
Chapter 9 — AI As Your Data Team	6,000	Month 6
Chapter 10 — The Future PR Strategist	6,000	Month 6
Conclusion	3,000	Month 6
Embedded case studies/examples throughout	7,000	Ongoing
TOTAL	75,000	6 Months

9. Endorsements

Below are people I'm confident will endorse my work. I haven't reached out yet but can as soon as the project moves forward. There are others I can contact too but below are a variety of regions.

1. [Sarah Waddington](#) CBE - PRCA CEO (UK based, global role)
2. [Nicole Moreo](#) - LinkedIn - Director of Marketing & tech (USA based, global role)

3. [Stephen Waddington](#) Wadds INc - Professional advisor to communications leaders & author (UK)
 4. [Sarah Evans](#) Zen Media - Head of PR & partner (USA)
 5. [James Alexander](#) Diageo - Global head of content (Earned & paid) (UK based, global role)
 6. [Celia Harding](#) Leoprd - Founder (Sydney Australia based, global role)
 7. [Jakrapong Kongmalai](#) Moonshot- Founder & PRCA Thailand Chair (Bangkok, Thailand)
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10. Marketing

The suggested audience below outlined for promotional activity is fully aligned with the intended readership of the book, consisting of PR and communications professionals working across agency and in-house environments, globally.

Through CoverageBook, industry partnerships, speaking engagements, podcasting, webinars, LinkedIn content, and educational initiatives, Stella Bayles regularly reaches communications practitioners actively involved in reporting, measurement, stakeholder communications, and strategic PR planning.

The audience profile is predominantly mid-to-senior level PR and communications professionals, including Account Managers, PR Managers, Account Directors, consultants, agency leaders, and in-house communications teams. The audience is primarily based across the UK and US, with additional reach across Europe, MENA, Australia, and wider international communications markets through industry partnerships and conferences.

Owned Audience & Content Channels

LinkedIn

Promotion will be supported through Stella Bayles' LinkedIn presence alongside CoverageBook and wider industry networks.

Current audience includes:

- [Stella Bayles LinkedIn](#): 3,328 followers + 1,823 connections
- [Gary Preston LinkedIn](#): 5,048 followers
- [CoverageBook LinkedIn](#): 2,762 followers

Stella's recent LinkedIn content has generated over 86,000 post impressions within the PR and communications industry audience.

Planned activity includes:

- pre-launch and launch content
- excerpt and insight-led content from the book
- webinar promotion
- podcast and speaking amplification

Additional targeted paid LinkedIn promotion may also be used to support visibility among PR and communications professionals.

Email Marketing Support

Promotion will also be supported through CoverageBook educational and customer email audiences, including:

- educational email audience: approximately 32,000
- newsletter audience: approximately 15,600
 - CTR average between 15-30% depending on content

Email activity will focus on:

- practical educational insights from the book
- measurement and AI-related communications topics
- webinar and podcast promotion
- launch announcements and purchase links

Podcast Platform

Stella Bayles hosts the long-running [PR Resolution Podcast](#), focused on PR, communications, SEO, analytics, and marketing technology.

The podcast has been running for approximately six years and provides an established platform for book-related promotion through:

- dedicated book-focused episodes
- guest interviews
- launch discussion episodes
- ongoing educational references tied to book themes

Current podcast reach includes:

- approximately 1,500–3,000 downloads per episode
- distribution across Spotify, Apple Podcasts, and major podcast platforms

Webinar & Educational Promotion

The book launch will also be supported through educational webinars and industry training sessions delivered through CoverageBook and industry partnerships.

Planned activity includes:

- dedicated webinar sessions focused on modern PR measurement
- AI and communications strategy discussions
- practical reporting and measurement workshops

Estimated webinar attendance:

- approximately 200 attendees per owned webinar session

Industry Partnerships & Speaking Opportunities

Stella Bayles regularly speaks at communications industry events and maintains active relationships with major industry bodies including PRCA and AMEC.

Potential promotional opportunities include:

- PRCA webinars and measurement-focused events
- AMEC Measurement Month activity
- AMEC International Summit speaking opportunities
- PRSA webinar opportunities
- guest appearances on PR and communications industry podcasts

Potential media and industry publication outreach includes:

- PR Week / Beyond the Noise
- PProvoke Media podcasts
- PR Daily
- Ragan Communications
- Communicate Magazine
- PR Moment

Promotion will be supported through established educational audiences, industry partnerships, regular speaking opportunities, podcasting, webinars, LinkedIn thought leadership, and direct access to PR and communications professionals globally.